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SETUP
Student Services App

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1. Introduction

Product Vision

As students of SETU, we aim to develop a dedicated, accessible student services product, that unifies the apps and utilities common to daily student life. The ideal SETU Personalised (SETUP) application integrates both existing and new educational and social features alike, giving staff & students more control over their educational experience, in real time, in one place.

To gain a better understanding of what we want SETUP to be, we investigated three existing products; Maynooth University App, xTiles & Studo. While each differs in scope and functionality, all serve as a reference point for different features SETUP implements.

A1. Maynooth University App

1. FOR Staff and students enrolled in Maynooth University [1]

2. WHO are interested in a service unique to the institution, with app features can be easily tailored to the needs of their userbase, such as:

- Campus Map Navigation
- MU Eduroam Setup
- University News & Events
- MU Clubs & Socs
- Commuting Info
- MU Eats

3. Released in 2022 with over 1k+ users, the **Maynooth University App** is a cross-platform **student services tool** students may avail of for its variety of educational and social features.[2]

It takes inspiration from similar purpose apps such as'Studo' [3], which integrates existing features from several apps into the one front-end interface.

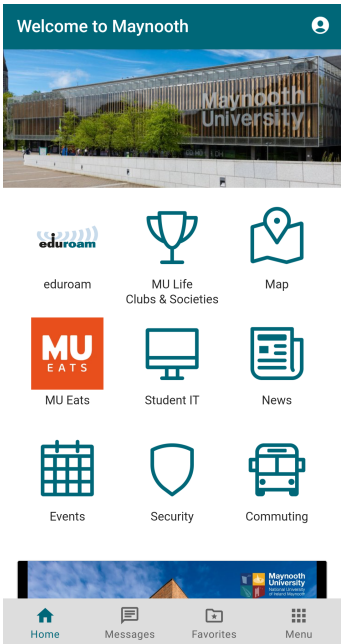

Fig 1. MU App Hompeage

When balancing reliance on third-parties, it's important to be realistic about development cost, time and ability. Often, it can be more redundant than useful to try reinvent the existing available tools,such as Moodle's learning environment, especially as a smaller team.

4. THAT prioritises a student life & learning centric approach to the platform. Supported by the college, it's free of costly subscription charges in order to have full functionality of the app.

5. UNLIKE alternatives such as Moodle, MU App's comprehensive design distinguishes itself from the more generalised alternatives on the market. By mitigating the reliance on third-party providers, MU has more flexibility in adapting to the needs of its users.

6. MAYNOOTH UNIVERSITY APP's design approach provides students with a service personalised to their institution. This close relationship between users, institution and developers makes it difficult for generalised competitors to fulfill the needs of its userbase as fluently.

The product serves as a reference point for similar SETUP development, given the comparable scale, resources and services ideal for both.

A2. xTiles

1. FOR Students and creative professionals, especially those seeking accessibility features.

2. WHO aim to visualise their workflow with a variety of templates and widgets.

3. XTILES is a **workspace and visual productivity platform** that is aimed towards daily planning, personal tasks, note-taking and project management.[4]

4. THAT Features drag-and-drop like moving texts, links and images that make it easy to rearrange your workspace. It is user-friendly and suitable for creating schedules and weekly study schedules. As a target demographic, students are provided special offers on paid plans.

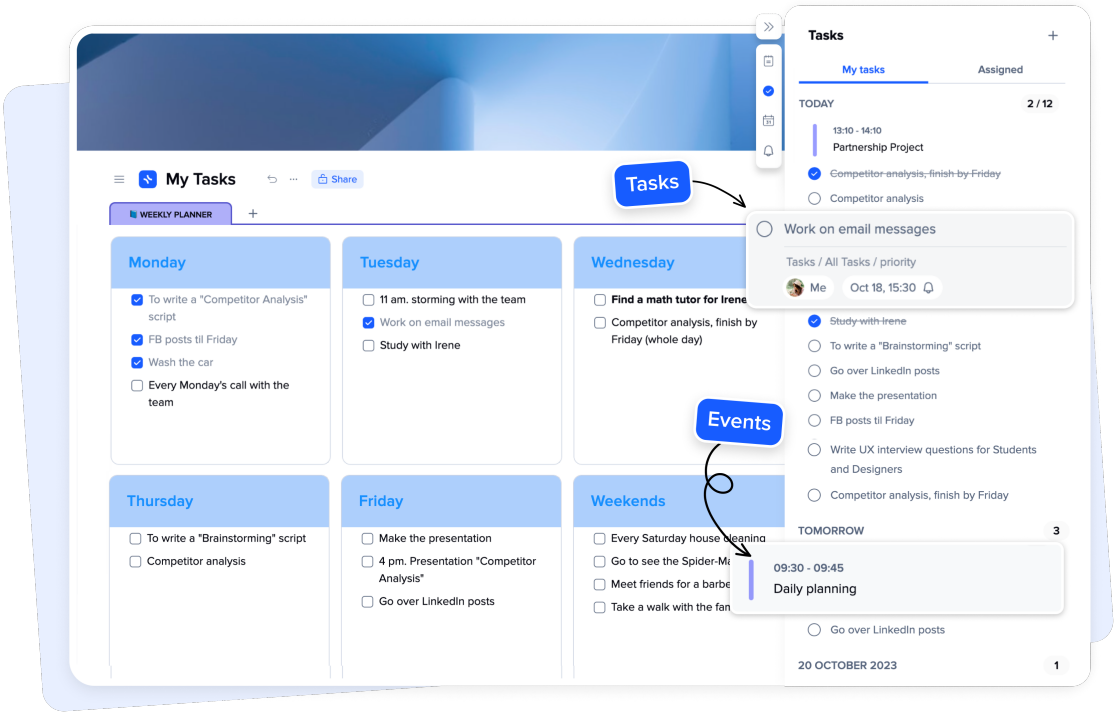

Fig 2. xTiles Interface

5. UNLIKE document-esque formatted alternatives, e.g. Microsoft Office 365, xTiles offers an at-a-glance overview of its users tasks, schedules and notes. First time users may find the UI of accessibility features provided by xTiles to be less intimidating for this reason. The lack of download or specific device requirements also make acess of the platform convenient, provided a user has reliable internet access.

6. XTILES design approach succeeds not on any one feature alone, but rather by providing its own visual spin on the popular features found across existing similar platforms;

- **Flexible** visual workspace where you can customize to your own needs.
  (Enables the user to add texts, images, links, etc.)
- **Real-time** multi-user support for collaboration.
  (Teams can work on a board together.)
- **Utilities** for making plans, brainstorms and organising.
- **Cross-platform**, accessible through multiple devices.
- **Integration** with other applications e.g. Google Calendar.
  (Allows events and deadlines to be synced across project.)

- **Templates** provided, giving users the option of customisation without the expectation of starting from scratch.
- Visually appealing and **intuitive UI** improves upon **accessibility** and engagement for ADHD, low-vision, etc.

When taking inspiration for the SETUP app, it's worth considering the reported limitations[5] of the platform:

- Lacking in **offline support**, making it unreliable for those without consistent internet.
- The large variety in tools can be offputting to new users without **clear instructions**.
- **Limited free plan** often pushes users into paid alternatives to access what some may expect to be basic features.

It's difficult for any project to predict how any given feature will be received or what challenges it may bring to development. For this reason, being receptive to user feedback at all stages of development can be hugely beneficial in the long-term.

A3. Studo

1. FOR Staff and students of any university eligible for use with Studo.

2. WHO are seeking a convenient all-in-one interface to access a range of student life and learning services.

3. STUDO is an app that provides a variety of **student and campus services**. The company partners with & supplies software across 60+ universities, with over 500k downloads on the mobile app version of its Studo student service.[3]

4. THAT,focuses on combining existing, but separate, platforms into one front-end application. e.g. SETU Timetable, student grades & Moodle access.

5. UNLIKE separated, smaller scope student services, which develop their platforms independently, e.g. Moodle/Outlook. Studo is not in competition with so much as it serves to integrate existing developed services into a convenient front-end interface for its user.

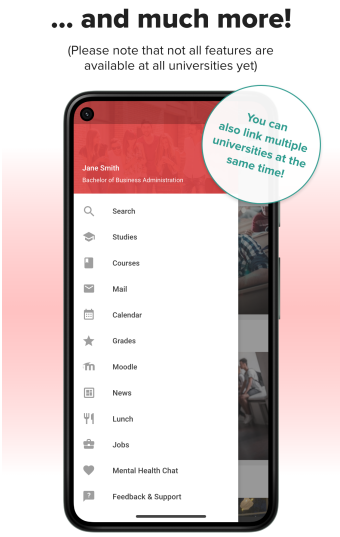

Fig 3. Studo Menu

6. STUDO distinguishes itself by focusing development on the following features:

- **All-in-one** interface for daily university/on-campus services (email, calendar, grades, timetables)
- **Real-Time** polls and push alerts
- **Easy integration** for existing records and student information
- **Accessible** course and grade overview. (highlights dates for assignments and uploads)
- **Synced** cross-platform from multiple devices
- University news feeds, vouchers, lunch menus

However, when considering its design for a SETUP application, note it's often criticised for:

- **Limited** or **redundant** features, many of which are heavily admin restricted.
- **Lack of customisation** options for students

- Chat feature between students is heavily moderated and **overly censorious**.
- 2FA and login features are unreliable, reported difficulty in students connecting accounts among other **integration issues**.

Features

Taking inspiration from the product vision cases above, we can use our analysis to form the foundation for the SETUP App's feature categories.

Many listed features exist in some form within the SETU website's student hub, meaning the infrastructure for supporting timetables, lab results, etc. will not have to be majorly altered to support the app.

Academic
Services related to a student's specific course.

- *Timetables*
  Timetable provided based on the details of a logged in user, eliminating the need to manually input details by default as seen on the existing timetable webpage.
- *Exam/Lab Results*
  Using moodle integration, congregate a students relevant lab results in the one place. Provide useful stats such as overall average, overall percent for a given lab, etc.
- *Academic Calendar*
  Relevant university events, allow editing for individual students to add their own information similar to a study planner.
- *To-Do/Notes Tool*
  Utility for quick notes, tracking of various deadlines set by Moodle, templates for study schedules.
- *Examinations*
  Upcoming student examinations, room details, etc.
- *Moodle Integration*
  In a similar fashion to Studo, integrate Moodle as a tab within the app directly.
- *Email Integration*
  Allow users to connect several email accounts, e.g. outlook, gmail, to the one inbox.

Student Life
Services related to a student's social life, not necessary course specific.

- *Clubs & Societies*
  Information on various clubs and societies, alongside options to pay membership.
- *News & Events*
  University updates, events, news. Opt-in follow to be notified for specific niches e.g. Computer Science Department events.
- *Transport Schedules*
  Bus/train commute info, could be integrated with services such as TFI.
- *Library*
  Options to reserve/renew loaned books, organise study pods, check opening hours, etc.
- *Campus Map*
  Integrated Google Map of the SETU campus, options to add custom markers, notes, etc. to buildings.

Support Services
University support services/utilities, grants & fee management.

- *Grants & Fees*
  Grant application info, student fee details, may be ideal to include information on external grants such as SUSI.
- *Disability Support*
  Contact info and associated systems for the disability service.
- *Counselling Services*
  Booking and associated systems for the counselling service.
- *Computer Services*
  Booking and associated systems for the computer service.
- *Eduroam & Printing Utilities*
  Wifi and printer setup.

User Experience
Broad considerations when implementing the above services.

- *Intuitive Design*
  Menus and layout should be concise and visually clear. Integrated first or third-party features should not be unnecessarily bloated or redundant.
- *Cross-Platform Sync*
  Sync a user across devices, (desktop, phone, etc.) and the SETU website when internet is available.
- *Offline Access*
  Allow users to save info such as timetables, lab results, etc. for use offline.
- *Feedback & Reports*
  Users should be able to report bugs, criticism or suggestions on improving the app.
- *Accessibility Tools*
  Settings for low-vision, colour-blind, screen-readers, etc.
- *Free and Efficient*
  Assuming development is supported by SETU, advertisements or paid premium memberships should not be expected. Exceptions for society memberships, student tuition fees.
- *Real-time Notifications*
  Users may opt-in to various push notifications, updates, etc.
- *GDPR compliant; data secure*
  Use of 2FA, privacy options, secure cloud storage handled by services like Cloudflare, Google Drive. Payment services also trusted to a third party such as stripe/google pay.

2. Personas

Definition

A user persona imagines a specific type of user for a given platform. e.g. SETUP, a student services app, may consider students, lecturers, and/or guests. Product expectations may vary depending on user background, education and skillset.

By conceptualising the types of users this product seeks to attract; personas assess what features are best to proritise. It also suggests what features may require further development, or scrapping entirely, in order for the product to be suitable for its demographics.

1. Connor Byrne, a Department of Science lecturer

Byrne is a 42 year old lecturer in the Department of Science at SETU. He specifically lecturers in classes relating to Biology or Pharmaceuticals. With over 10 years of experience in teaching in this field, he delivers modules to undergraduates, supervises final year research projects, and contributes to the research conducted by the university.

Byrne manages large amounts of students across different groups each semester, often trying to balance lecturing, grading, meetings, research deadlines, and to stay in touch with students who may have questions. Byrne finds students contacting him across a plethera of platforms, most being Slack, Moodle, Outlook, Teams, etc. He finds that switching between these apps to keep track of messages is time-consuming and inefficient.

Byrne would benefit from an app like SETUP, which allows for all these platforms to be confined to a central hub. This would also help him manage schedueling meetings with students and staff, grading, exam timetables, as these can be tasks that are done automatically. Reducing the amount of repetitive tasks and simplifying it down to a reporting process would significantly improve his workflow.

Seemless integration and local navigation of all the socail platforms that the university uses will allow him to stay up-to-date and in frequent contact with his research group, fellow staff, and all the students that attempt to reach out to him.

2. Maria Angelo, a mature nursing student

Maria Angelo, 46 years old, mother of two daughters. She is a nurse who works in a local hospital, aiding patients in need of care. She graduated out of nursing school when she was 22 years old in the Philippines. By age 30 she had the opportunity to work in Ireland, where she met her lovely husband 2 years later. They live in the suburb with their daughters, a 12 years old and and a 14 year old who attend first and third year of secondary school respectively.

Maria has been in the nursing field for 23 years, now she wants to specialise in a different area which requires certification. She decides to go back to college and start studying again. Maria is a busy woman, now that she must balance returning to education, working overtime in hospital and minding her daughters. With her busy schedule, she would miss deadlines for her assignments and would have to contact her lecturers to have an extension.

With the help of SETUP, she can create her schedules, check lists of her tasks and additional information. This will assist her time schedule, as it includes an automated timetable specifically for the user. There's a board for the user to write up their personal to-do list and it traces deadlines that is set by Moodle. She can email her lecturers through the app as well as receiving them.

Instead of going through different applications for peculiar tasks, SETUP would allow her do it all in one application. The built-in integrations and neat GUI will help set personal schedules, tick off her to-do lists and request deadline extensions when necessary to her lecturers.

3. Jane, an accounting student with accessibility concerns

Jane is a 20 year old first year undergraduate, pursuing a BA (Hons) in Accounting at SETU. She has been receiving good grades and is an active member of the SETU snowboarding society. She commutes two hours by bus from Wexford for her 9am-5pm weekly classes.

She has experienced difficulty in navigating the various grants and accomodation forms, and would appreciate an app that makes booking appointments with services such as MABS, counselling or the disability office more straightforward.

ADHD can cause Jane to become disorganised with her appointments, because of this she keeps a physical journal. Unfortunately, she does not always remember to keep this journal updated, so having an

automated digital calendar for academic and social events would be useful.

Jane also uses a low vision setting on her phone for app navigation, she's noticed a lack of support in many online services for this feature. SETUP should consider the accessibility needs of users like Jane when developing upon its services.

3. Scenarios

Definition

etc. etc.

Scenario 1

etc. etc.

Scenario 2 - Connor Byrne, Department of Science Lecturer

One module that Byrne teaches is structured to have many small bi-weekly Mulitple Choice Question quizzes based on material and topics covered over the weeks. Byrne is preparing teaching materials for this module at the beginning of the semester but has previously found it difficult to be consistent with reminders about the quizzes as announcements across Moodle, email, and in-class reminders were often missed or overlooked.

Using SETUP, Byrne can schedule all the quizzes through the built in academic calender, which will automatically sync with students personal timetables. He can choose for these quizzes to send push notification alerts to the students if it is a certain amount of time before each quiz, for example, 2 days and 24 hours before.

Byrne can also contact students easier through SETUP and stay consistently in touch with any questions or queries about the MCQ without needing to check multiple platforms. Students can view the quiz details, deadline, study material, and any feedback after the quiz.

This helps Byrne improve student engagement and fewer missed assesments, but also allows him to spend less time sending repeated reminders or responding to questions across multiple platforms which allows him more focus on teaching and research.

Scenario 3

etc. etc.

4. User Stories

Definition

etc. etc.

User Story 1

As a Lecturer who also works in research groups within the university, I want:

- To be able to quickly contact or jump between conversations with students and with the research group.

- To provide fast information to students about assesments, deadlines, changes to timetables, etc.
- To easily share resources such as lecture notes, links to resources, file uploads, etc, with other peeople on the platform.
- To manage all communication in a clean and efficient manner to keep in contact and up-to-date.

User Story 2

As a department staff member who helps moderate the platform, I want:

- To manage and update university-wide announcemnts, events, important notices, etc.
- To have the ability to help solve user-realted issues, such as login problems or incorrect user information.
- To control access permissions for different user roles, such as students, lecturers, department leads, etc.
- To review feedback and reports submitted by users to improve the platform.

User Story 3

etc. etc.

User Story 4

etc. etc.

User Story 5

etc. etc.

User Story 6

etc. etc.

5. Prototype

Definition

etc. etc.

Tools Used

description, ease of use, brief.

Media (URLs, Screenshots)

sample of relevant urls, screenshots.
Studo Website : https://studo.com/en
Studo Reviews : https://chrome-stats.com/d/com.moshbit.studo

6. References

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